

Westerns: A Study in Revisionist Genres

The Western is one of the longest-running genres associated with American cinema and as American society and its values evolved, so did the Western. While classic Westerns such as John Ford's *Stagecoach* (1939) depict a rugged frontier where the American spirit is embodied by a Western hero and their use of violence, revisionist Westerns like *Unforgiven* (1992) question and subvert these themes and conventions. There are few people more tied to the Western genre than Clint Eastwood and his career offers a compelling case study to explore the different cycles of the Western genre. From his role as Rowdy Yates in the TV series *Rawhide* to his Spaghetti Westerns with director Sergio Leone, to finally his later movies in which he both directed and acted. His transition from actor to director mirrors the broader transformation of the Western itself: from heroic mythmaking to critical self-reflection.

The Western story predates cinema itself, rooted in the mythologizing of the historical westward expansion of the nineteenth century. Yet, as Thomas Schatz in *Hollywood Genres* points out it wasn't until "its immortalization on film, however, did the Western genre certify its mythic credentials."¹ In other words, while the myths of the American frontier already existed through literature, music, and popular culture it was the medium of film that solidified it into a distinctive genre and brought it to a wider audience. Western movies evolved alongside the development of cinema. From the start Western films were on the silver screen from *The Great Train Robbery* (1903) to *The Iron Horse* (1924) and more Westerns dominated the silent movie era. For a short period, Westerns fell out of popularity and survived as low-budget B-movies before the genre was revitalized in the so-called golden age of Westerns that went from the late 1930s to the 1950s.

1. Thomas Schatz, *Hollywood Genres: Formulas, Filmmaking, and the Studio System* (Boston, Mass: McGraw-Hill, 2009), 45.

It is in this period that Westerns began to look increasingly similar—and thus a recognizable genre is formed—with nearly every story depicting the same central struggle, as Schatz states, “the Western depicts a world of precarious balance in which the forces of civilization and savagery are locked in a struggle for supremacy.”² In answer to this conflict, certain character archetypes emerged to embody either side of the binary. On one side stands the law and order: the rancher; the sheriff; and the homesteader; all figures symbolizing stability, civilization, and community. Opposing them were the outlaws, bandits, thieves, and often an “other” figure drawn from marginalized groups such as the Native Americans or Mexicans (frequently portrayed in deeply racist ways) who were all depicted as threats to the fragile social order. At the center of these films was the Western hero, typically an isolated man with a strong sense of personal justice—a cowboy, sheriff, or lone gunman—whose heroic moral values set him apart from the community that he protects.

John Ford’s *Stagecoach* (1939) exemplifies this traditional Western world. The towns that the stagecoach and its passengers travel between act as microcosms of civilized society, oases surrounded by the vast wilderness of Hollywood’s mythologized West. The passengers themselves represent different facets of this conflict – the lawman, an embezzling/corrupt banker, a drunken doctor, and a ladylike prostitute – all sharing the same stagecoach. John Wayne’s Ringo Kid in particular serves “a living manifestation of the Western’s basic conflicts.” who “must find his own way through an environment of contrary and ambiguous demands” according to Schatz.³ Though technically an outlaw (a convict) Ringo is guided by his own sense of justice. His moral code, loyalty to his friends, and determination to avenge his murdered family position him closer to the forces of civilization than to those of savagery. Also displayed in *Stagecoach* is

2. Schatz, *Hollywood Genres*, 47.

3. Schatz, *Hollywood Genres*, 50

the Western hero's use of ritualistic violence. As Carl Plantinga explains "In the Western myth, ritualized it cleanses society of the 'Other' in eliminating the outlaw of the 'savage'."⁴ The wilderness is embodied by the Native American "threat" which the passengers and must overcome in the climatic shootout typical of Western films.

Importantly, classic Westerns were not aiming for realism or historical accuracy but worked to reinforce familiar troupes and myths. As noted by Thomas Sobchack, "They [Genre films] are made in imitation not of life but of other films."⁵ Rather than offering a one-to-one portrayal of frontier life, these films built upon each other to establish a symbolic world that audiences could recognize, relate to, and increasingly expect. Thematically, classic Westerns often celebrated the expansion of American civilization as both inevitable and righteous, reinforcing national ideals of progress and moral certainty. However, this American optimism began to fade as the social and political landscape of the 1960s and 1970s shifted dramatically. American historian John Mack Faragher states that "divisions over the war in Vietnam and the meaning of American democracy fractured the ideological consensus behind the Western"⁶ Alongside this was the growing counterculture and the Civil Rights Movement which challenged traditional social norms regarding race, gender, and sexuality. These changes caused new Westerns released in the 60s to be dismissed "for their repetition of hollow pieties."⁷

As the traditional Western lost its cultural resonance, the genre began to shift and change to stay relevant. This brings up the argument that Leger Grindon makes of genres containing

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4. Carl Plantinga, "Spectacles of Death: Clint Eastwood and Violence in '*Unforgiven*.'" *Cinema Journal* 37, no. 2 (1998), 65.
 5. Thomas Sobchack, "Genre Film: A Classical Experience", chapter in *Film Genre Reader* (University of Texas Press, 2012), 123.
 6. John Mack Faragher, "Clint Eastwood's *Unforgiven*: The Western Is Back." (*Montana: The Magazine of Western History* 43, no. 1, 1993), 76
 7. Faragher, "Clint Eastwood's *Unforgiven*: The Western Is Back.", 76.

cycles, “a distinctive and more focused category” within a larger tradition.⁸ Grindon argues that genres, as reflections of societal values and anxieties must adapt over time. Few figures are more associated with the shifting of the Western genre than Clint Eastwood who is often credited with the death of the traditional Western hero and the creation of the “Man with No Name” persona which replaced it.

Clint Eastwood’s early career reflected the lingering influence of the classical Western period. His breakout role as Rowdy Yates in the television series *Rawhide* (1959–1965) cast him firmly within the familiar Western mold. As Yates, Eastwood portrayed a young, earnest cowboy who operated within the established codes of loyalty, justice, and frontier honor. However, Eastwood’s later collaboration with director Sergio Leone in the so-called spaghetti westerns marked a decisive departure from these conventions and signaled the formation of a new cycle within the genre.

In Leone’s Dollars trilogy—*A Fistful of Dollars* (1964), *For a Few Dollars More* (1965), and *The Good, the Bad and the Ugly* (1966)—Eastwood took the role of the “Man with No Name” a new character type for which he would become famous for playing. Unlike the upright heroes of earlier Westerns, Eastwood’s Man with No Name was a clear break from the traditional ideals, presenting a figure full of moral ambiguity. Rather than operating according to a personal code of justice, his code is concerned with survival and personal gain. His use of violence is not framed as noble or redemptive but rather as a practical and self-serving tool for navigating a brutal, lawless environment.

8. Leger Grindon, “Cycles and Clusters: The Shape of Film Genre History”, chapter in *Film Genre Reader IV* (University of Texas Press, 2012), 45

In *A Fistful of Dollars*, Eastwood's character—named Joe but often referred to simply as “the American” or “the stranger”—arrives at a small border town where death hangs heavy as two families fight for control. Early in the film, the Stranger guns down four men who had insulted him, not out of a sense of moral duty or vengeance, but as a calculated assertion of power. Throughout the film, his loyalty shifts between the two feuding families, playing both sides in a ruthless gambit for money. The world of *A Fistful of Dollars* is full of pervasive lawlessness and corruption. However, amidst his cynicism and violence are moments of stark vulnerability that give this character depth and separate him from the villainous characters. A key moment in *A Fistful of Dollars* is when the Stranger decides to help Marisol, a woman caught in the rivalry, reuniting her to her family and giving them money to get to the border and escape. When Marisol asks the Stranger why he is helping them he replies with, “Why? ‘Cause I knew someone like you once. There was no one there to help.”⁹ This simple yet poignant line humanizes the Stranger and endears him to the audience. This fleeting admission suggests that underneath the mask of indifference the Man with No Name is motivated by more than self-preservation and greed.

While Leone and Eastwood's “Man with No Name” character rejects the morality of traditional Western heroes, the violence in these films still retains a conventional separation between “good” or “bad” violence.¹⁰ The Stranger's violence, though ruthless, was often directed against characters who were depicted as worse. In *A Fistful of Dollars*, Ramon tortures characters, kidnaps Marisol, and sets fire to Baxter's house shooting them as they try to flee, this

9. Sergio Leone dir., *A Fistful of Dollars*, performed by Clint Eastwood (1964; Italy: MGM), Amazon Prime Video.

10. Plantinga, “Spectacles of Death”, 73.

makes his defeat by Eastwood's character cathartic and aligns it with the traditional Western code of justified versus unjustified violence.

The violence and moral ambiguity seen in *A Fistful of Dollars* are taken to an even greater extreme in *The Good, The Bad, and The Ugly*, culminating in the final showdown between the three title characters. In this scene, Leone's signature style works to transform the symbolic Western shootout into a long moment of tension and visual spectacle. His dramatic close-ups and extreme close-ups capture every detail of the characters from their eyes flicking between opponents, their hands hovering over their guns, to the sweat dripping down their faces the actors' emotions are on full display. These shots are intercut with wide shots that establish the circle which the three men make and the desolate landscape they are in. Combined with the beautiful composition "The Trio" by Ennio Morricone, which is the only noise to be heard for minutes, Leone draws out this shootout for over five-minute building tension until the end when the music crescendos the cuts become faster, and guns are finally fired. In the spaghetti Western violence is both stylized and extreme.

In the 1970s, Eastwood transitioned into directing, continuing to rework the Western genre through a series of revisionist Westerns such as *High Plains Drifter* (1973), *Pale Rider* (1985), and *Unforgiven*. These films while showcasing familiar characters, settings, and plots, work to deconstruct the ideals of heroism, justice, and redemption associated with the Western genre. According to Fred Erisman, "Eastwood uses his knowledge of the modes and conventions of the Western film to examine the nature of the mythic Western hero in the closing days of the twentieth century."¹¹ *Unforgiven* breathes new life into Eastwood's famous Man with No Name

11. Fred Erisman, "CLINT EASTWOOD'S WESTERN FILMS AND THE EVOLVING MYTHIC HERO." (*Hungarian Journal of English and American Studies (HJEAS)*, 2000), 129–43.

character as Eastwood plays William Munny a former outlaw deeply haunted by his violent past. When Munny accepted the job present by the Schofield Kid (Jaimz Woolvett), he struggles to saddle his horse and misses several practice shots with his pistol—the iconic Western weapon—showing he is out of practice. These qualities usually associated with the Western hero are nowhere to be found. Instead, Eastwood projects his own image as an aged actor onto Munny, intensifying the character’s image as a broken man. Unlike the stoic detachment and the physical prowess of the Man with No Name in Leone’s spaghetti Westerns, Munny’s humanity and conscience are always present making him a far more tragic and complex figure.¹²

Unforgiven serves both as a tribute to and a critique of the genre that made Eastwood famous. Rather than portraying violence as a righteous act that redeems characters, in *Unforgiven* violence is a persistent and sinister force perpetuated by fear, greed, and the myths that glorify it. It also is infectious as Plantinga describes, “As the spiral of vengeful acts spins downward, it also expands outward, sucking a broadening spectrum of humanity into the vortex.”¹³ In the town of Big Whiskey, every character is caught up in this cycle: from Little Bill’s displays of brutality justified as necessary to maintain order, to the prostitutes seeking revenge, to Schofield Kid whose exaggerated story convinces Munny to join him. Even Munny, who had thought his wife had cured him of his wickedness, finds himself dragged back into the cycle of violence. Eastwood presents a harsh world in which everyone is complicit in the violence surrounding Big Whiskey. The cyclical nature of violence becomes most evident in the film’s brutal climax at Skinny’s saloon. Munny’s rampage is not portrayed as heroic but as inevitable, a tragic consequence of the endless escalation of revenge and retaliation.

12. Faragher, Clint Eastwood’s *Unforgiven*: The Western Is Back,

13. Plantinga, *Spectacles of Death*, 79.

It is with this film that Eastwood not only revises the Western but also receives his most critical acclaim. Winning Academy Awards for both his directing and acting in *Unforgiven*. This success draws attention to the way the Western genre's reputation has shifted over time. Once dismissed as being formulaic or lowbrow humor, revisionist films such as *Unforgiven* brought about a new respect. Revisionist Westerns continue to serve as vehicles for critical reflection and critique proving that the past can be a powerful lens to explore contemporary ideals.

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